

An Easy-to-Follow Git Based Development Workflow

This article provides a cookbook-style Git workflow to help project teams and developers. The workflow is intended for small open source projects that have a few people as maintainers and multiple developers contributing to them.



Git is a powerful distributed version control system that is free and open source. It was created by Linus Torvalds in 2005 when the Linux project had to move away from BitKeeper. Since then, there has been constant addition of functionality and improvement in performance. Today, it is recognised as one of the fastest distributed version control systems. As a result, in the past few years, many open source projects have migrated to Git from SVN, CVS and other version control systems.

However, the power of Git also means that it can be incorrectly used, resulting in confusing revision history after merges and consequent difficulties in tracking code changes. At worst, it could result in loss of code as well. Also, many developers with a background in centralised version control

find it difficult to understand the distributed nature of Git and how to use it effectively. This has created a mental barrier, where project teams hesitate to use Git, due to its perceived difficulty and uncertainty in workflow.

There are many books that describe how to use Git and also cover its internals. But these get into complex details, and do not provide a template workflow that can be used by project teams that are embarking on new development but are new to Git.

Installation and initial configuration

Git is packaged by most Linux distributions. So you can use *apt*, *yum* or any other package management system provided by your distribution to install Git.

However, in case the version provided by your